

Observations on Speech #2

- The opening and closing narrative reports correspond in terms of command and fulfillment.
- The three movements of the speech go from Noah’s character, which warrants the following directives, to God’s command that he rescue the animals and keep them alive.
- This speech seems especially tuned into the garden narrative, where humans are both priests and caretakers of the animals, which explains the purity categories that differentiate the animals. Notice also the vocabulary of “causing rain” (7:4 ממטיר) links back to the beginning of the garden narrative (2:2-5 “before there was yet rain”).

Observations on the Relationships Between the Two Speeches

- Both speeches begin with a report of divine speech and end with statements of Noah’s action according to what was commanded.
- Speech #1 begins by focusing on the corruption of the land that warrants the flood of judgment, while speech #2 begins with Noah’s right standing before God.
- Speech #1 alone has instructions for the making of the ark; speech #2 assumes the existence of an ark to enter into.
- Speech #1 directs Noah to bring his family and the animals into the ark. The animals are described in the language of Genesis 1 (“after their kind” and birds/animals/creepers refer back to Gen. 1:21, 24-25). In speech #2, the animals are described in priestly categories using the language of the garden story (“a man and his wife,” “two” refer to Gen. 2:23-24).

Noah the Righteous Remnant

In Genesis 7:1, God reaffirms Noah’s righteous character, which was first stated by the narrator in 6:8-9. But the repetition is strategic because a key narrative moment takes place between the two statements.

Narrator’s Statement	Noah’s Obedience	God’s Statement	
Genesis 6:8-9 Noah found favor in the eyes of Yahweh. Noah was a righteous man , blameless he was in his generations . Noah walked with God.	Genesis 6:13-14 The end of all flesh has come before me, for the land is filled with violence before them ... Make for yourself an ark ...	Genesis 6:22 And Noah did according to everything that Elohim commanded him, so he did it.	Genesis 7:1 Go, you and all your house into the ark, for I have seen that you are righteous before me in this generation .
<i>Noah’s Righteousness.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).			

Noah’s actions in the intervening narrative connect the narrator’s statement and God’s statement in an action-consequence relationship: Noah was a righteous man already, but God’s command to him was a test to prove his character. Noah passes the test, and God then reaffirms his promise of salvation.

God provides the place of refuge for the righteous remnant.

"[I]t is significant that only immediately before his final entry into the ark did Noah learn of God's plan to destroy mankind by a flood. Of course, only by this communication could the meaning of the ark and its purpose become clear to him. Therefore, Noah completed the entire structure without knowing God's intentions; he had only the command which drove him to blind obedience. But that was just Yahweh's intention—to test Noah. To Noah the command must have seemed strange and incomprehensible. A ship on dry land! That was a test of his obedience and faith. But he passed the test, just as Abraham later followed God's command implicitly ([Gen. 12:4](#)). 'By faith Noah being warned by God concerning events as yet unseen, took heed and constructed an ark for the saving of his household.' ([Heb. 11:7](#)). When one sees that [the narrator] here tells of a test of faith that was passed, then one also understands the judgment which Noah now learns from God's mouth (i.e., after the command to build and his completion of the building). The [narrator] did not simply assert Noah's 'righteousness' ... but he described it! Unfortunately, we have no satisfactory English word for the theologically significant word *ṣaddīq* ('righteous'). According to the Old Testament the *ṣaddīq* ('righteous person') does justice to a relationship in which he stands. If God abides by his covenant, acts according to the covenant, then he is 'righteous.' If a human stands in right relation to God, i.e., believes, trusts God, then he is 'righteous.' Righteousness in this sense is not a juridical term of relation, but rather a theological one (see also at Gen. 15:6)."

Von Rad, Gerhard (1973). [Genesis: A Commentary](#). Westminster John Knox Press.

Reflection Question

God rescues Noah's entire family on account of Noah's righteous obedience. What does this invite us to consider about God's nature and the way he interacts with people?

Session 13: The Ark as a Symbolic Eden and Tabernacle

Key Takeaways

- The word *tebah*, translated as “ark,” is an Egyptian loanword that means sacred shrine, sarcophagus, or box.
- The ark is a symbolic Eden temple. Its design matches the three-tiered structure of sacred spaces: the garden in Eden, the tabernacle, and the temple.

The Design of Noah’s Ark

“While popular depictions of the ark often mislead one into viewing it as a boat, the vessel, having no sails, rudder, oarsman, etc., was no boat, and Noah was no 'captain' steering his own fate. Indeed, that the ark was completely given over to the sovereign guidance of God seems to be a primary emphasis of the narrative ... [T]he instructions to build the ark in Gen 6:13-17 utilize three times as many verses than for the flood itself, demonstrating ... the emphasis on the ark itself as the means of deliverance. How would ancient readers have understood the ark? Several considerations lead to the conclusion that the ark was meant to be seen as symbolizing a temple.”

Morales, Michael (2012). [*The Tabernacle Pre-Figured: Cosmic Mountain Ideology in Genesis and Exodus*](#). Peeters Publishers. 146-147.

The Word Ark (*Tebah*)

The Hebrew word for Noah’s ark is “*tebah*” (Heb. תבה), and in the Hebrew Bible it appears only in the Genesis flood story and the story of Moses’ deliverance through an ark (*tebah* is usually translated as “basket”).

The rare word *tebah* is actually an Egyptian loanword (*dbt*) into Hebrew, which means “sacred shrine, sarcophagus, box.”

For more information on this word, see Kohler and Baumgartner’s book *The Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old Testament* (1,678) and Yoshiyuki Muchiki’s book *Egyptian Proper Names and Loanwords in North-West Semitic* (59).

The sense of “sacred shrine” is significant for the ark’s cultural and symbolic meaning in this story.

“Whereas [the word ‘*tebah*’] is applied to a ship in the flood story (Gen. 6:14), it is being used in its real meaning of ‘chest, holy shrine, coffin.’ Such a chest generally had the form of a divine shrine, and served as housing for images of gods which were dedicated to temples. Of the numerous shrines which have been

preserved several are in stone of different qualities, while others are in plain wood ... The simpler ones ... [had] the form of a longish chest with a small door in the upper portion of the front for statues of gods about the size of a child. Such chests or arks were to be found in all the Egyptian temples from the earliest to the latest times, and they were duly noted by the Greek writers ... On certain festivals as well as on the occasion of great victory fetes they were borne in solemn procession, or were carried on the Nile, from one temple-town to another, on a bier which was usually given the form of a bark, such as was conceived as vehicle for the sun god Re, Osiris, and other gods."

Yahudah, Abraham S. (2003). [*Language of the Pentateuch in its Relation to Egyptian*](#). Kessinger Publishing. 205.

"The word ... 'ark' occurs in only two sections of Scripture: here (Gen. 6:14-15) and in the section that describes the birth and rescue of Moses (Exod. 2:3-5). This is certainly no coincidence. By the verbal parallel, the Torah wished, apparently, to draw attention to the parallelism of theme. In both cases there is to be saved from drowning one who is worthy of salvation and is destined to bring deliverance to others; here it is humanity that is to be saved, there it is the chosen people; here it is the macrocosm that has to be preserved, there it is the microcosm."

Cassuto, Umberto (2012). [*A Commentary on the Book of Genesis: From Noah to Abraham*](#). Varda Books. 59.

The Materials of the Ark

The materials of the ark listed in 6:14 contain a puzzle that is elegantly solved by adopting the translation "reeds" (Heb. *qanim*) instead of "nests/rooms" (Heb. *qinniym*). The most compelling case for this reading has been made by John Day in the chapter titled "Rooms or Reeds in Noah's Ark (Genesis 6:14)?" in his book *From Creation to Babel: Studies in Genesis 1-11* (Day, 2014).

Genesis 6:14 Instructor's Translation

Make for yourself an ark of gopher (גפר) trees
you will make the ark (a) "with nests" OR (b) "of reeds,"
and you will pitch (כפר) it inside and out with pitch (כפר).

The Masoretic Text contains the consonant *q-n-y-m* with the vowel points *qinniym* (קִנִּיִּים) so that the word means "nests." This is the standard Hebrew word for a bird's nest, although it can sometimes be used metaphorically for a human dwelling located high in the hills for security like a nest.

Bird's Nest

Deuteronomy 22:6 NASB

"If you happen to come upon a **bird's nest** along the way, in any tree or on the ground, with young ones or eggs ...

Psalms 84:3 NASB

The bird also has found a house,
and the swallow a **nest** for herself, where she may lay her young,

even your altars, O LORD of hosts,
my King and my God.

See also Deut. 32:11; Job 39:27; Prov. 27:8; Isa. 10:14, 16:12

Human Dwelling Portrayed as a Bird's Nest

Numbers 24:21 NASB*

And he looked at the Caninite (קניני), and took up his discourse and said,
"Your dwelling place is enduring,
And your **nest** (קן) is set in the cliff.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Obadiah 1:4 NASB

"Though you build high like the eagle,
Though you set your **nest** among the stars,
From there I will bring you down," declares the LORD.

See also Jer. 49:16; Hab. 2:9

While a human dwelling can be likened to a bird's nest, it's clear that the word refers metaphorically to an entire dwelling and that the bird's nest image is part of why the word was chosen. The word does not refer to the particular room of a dwelling in any of the examples in the Hebrew Bible. Therefore, the translation "rooms" is not supported by any contextual evidence. And yet it is the translation adopted by most modern English translations.

There is an overwhelming amount of evidence that the word means "reeds" and was originally vocalized with different vowels, *qaniym* (קניִים), which means "reeds" and is an active word in biblical Hebrew (1 Kgs. 14:15; 2 Kgs. 18:21; Isa. 19:6).

This interpretation is likely for a number of reasons.

- Genesis 6:14 is a three-part description of the materials of the ark. The dimensions and internal design of the ark is briefly described only in 6:15-16. The mention of "rooms" here is out of place.
- Genesis 6:14-16 contains instructions on the topics of materials, dimensions, and design in sequence, and each topic is described in three lines. This makes it likely that the word "*qnym*" is referring to materials.

Pattern	Verse
Materials 1	¹⁴ Make for yourself an ark of gopher (גפר) trees;
Three-Part Descriptions of Material, Dimensions, and Design of the Ark. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	